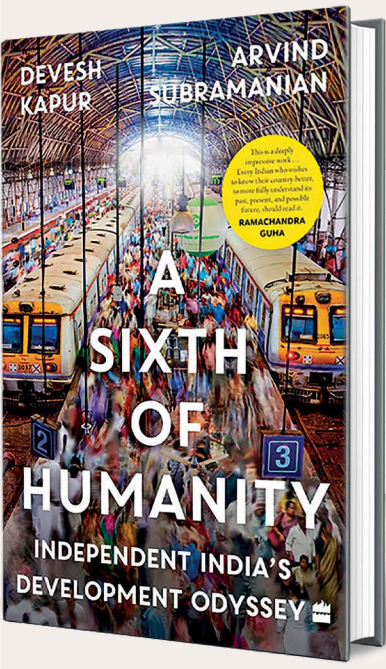



**A SIXTH OF HUMANITY**
**Independent India's Development Odyssey**
*By Devesh Kapur and Arvind Subramanian*
HARPERCOLLINS
**₹1,299; 760 pages**

BOOKS ▼

# AN IMMERSIVE **CHRONICLE**

***A SIXTH OF HUMANITY*** OFFERS A DEEPLY RESEARCHED ACCOUNT OF INDIA'S COMPLEX DEVELOPMENT STORY

**In a world where 30-second TikTok clips masquerade as analysis, a 760-page book on India's development story is a deliberate act of defiance. *A Sixth of Humanity*, authored by Devesh Kapur and Arvind Subramanian—both respected scholars, with the latter having served as India's Chief Economic Advisor—offers a sweeping, meticulously researched account of India's post-Independence journey.**

**The book undertakes the ambitious task of chronicling independent India's tryst with development. This is no small feat, given the vast array of literature that already exists on the subject. For me, what distinguishes it from the others is the authors' disciplined refusal to rely on hindsight when evaluating policy decisions, reforms and political events. Instead, they strive to understand choices as they were made, immersing and limiting the reader only to the information and context available at the time.**

**This approach is more challenging than it appears. Most analyses fall into the trap of judging past decisions and events based on their outcomes. For instance, it is now commonplace to attribute much of India's current woes to the 'socialistic' planning of the 1950s and '60s.**

**Such assessments, however, are inevitably coloured by knowledge of what happened later. Instead, set aside the benefit of hindsight and consider the daunting circumstances faced by India's first policymakers: a vast, uneducated and impoverished population, deeply divided by religion, language, culture, and caste; limited state capacity; the need to establish law and order, build an economy, transform an illiberal society, and foster a sense of nationhood—all within the framework of a liberal democracy. A decentralised market economy, dominated by a handful of trading houses and feudal landlords, is unlikely to have been the natural starting point.**

**The book also resists the urge to end with a perfunctory prescriptive chapter of solutions. As one of the authors noted in a panel discussion, the 'what' of India's challenges is well-known; it's the 'how' that remains contentious. The authors, however, suggest, perhaps wryly, that the state's minimum responsibility is not to undermine India's democratic, legal, educational and policy institutions.**

**Yet, the book is not without its shortcomings made stark by the otherwise deep scholarship. Its thematic structure—dividing the narrative into sections on the economy, the state, and nation-building—gives the impression that the complex web of factors influencing decisions and events can be separated into neat silos. Caste, for instance, is treated mainly as a nation-building issue, despite its malignant impact on economic development and state capacity. Rather surprisingly, the private sector is portrayed as passively reacting to state policy rather than actively trying to shape it, often to profit from the regulatory arbitrage they themselves helped to create.**

**Despite these flaws, *A Sixth of Humanity* with its disciplined methodology and refusal to indulge in easy answers make it a standout contribution to the literature on India's development. ■**

**IN AN AGE OF INSTANT OPINIONS, THE BOOK IS A REMINDER OF THE VALUE OF DEPTH, CONTEXT AND ACADEMIC DISCIPLINE**

***—Jahangir Aziz***
*Chief Emerging Markets Economist, J.P. Morgan*
*(These are the author's personal views)*